opposed the renaming of the town, saying the people of the district were not consulted before it was done. "You can tear out pages from history books, but you cannot change history...," he says, adding that for him, "it was, is and will always be Aurangabad". Jaleel says the ruling regime was just raking up "emotional issues" while ignoring critical ones such as water scarcity and the farmer suicides in the region. The Centre's decision also comes at a time when the issue is sub judice. In a bid to put the state government on the back foot, Jaleel asks why cities such as Mumbai, Kolhapur, Nagpur and Pune are not being named after Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, Chhatrapati Rajarshi Shahu Maharaj, Dr B.R. Ambedkar and Savitribai Phule, respectively?

Incidentally, the late polymath Sharad Patil, who blended Marxism with the ideology of Jotiba Phule and Ambedkar, had wanted Aurangabad to be renamed 'Malik Ambarabad' after Nizamshahi general Malik Ambar. Ambar, an Abyssinian slave who became a Nizamshahi general, had not only laid the foundations of the present town at village Khadki here but pretty much been the first bulwark of the Deccan against imperial Delhi in the medieval ages—a role that was to be later performed by the Marathas in a line of continuity not always acknowledged.

Maharashtra takes its cultural markers and political totems seriously. In 1978, the Sharad Pawar-led Progressive Democratic Front (PuLod) coalition decided to name the Marathwada University in Aurangabad after Ambedkar, a move that caused much resentment among the dominant Maratha community and a backlash against the Dalits in the region. The university was eventually renamed 'Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar Marathwada University' in 1994 with a new varsity named after Swami Ramanand Tirtha, the hero of the Marathwada liberation movement, being created at Nanded as a consolation prize for the critics.

The 'Namantar' movement that called for the renaming produced Dalit leaders like Union MoS and Republican Party of India (RPI) chief Ramdas Athavale and former MP Jogendra Kawade. It also led to counter-mobilisation from the dominant castes, resulting in the Shiv Sena gaining political space in Marathwada, its first opening outside the Mumbai-Thane region. The social cleavages that resulted from the decade-and-a-half-long movement persist in the Marathwada region even today.

The 'Sambhajinagar' decision by the Union ministry of home affairs has now snowballed with renewed demands for names of cities and even railway stations to be changed. Gopichand Padalkar, BJP MLC and leader of the Dhangar community, wants Ahmednagar district—named after Ahmed Nizamshah, who founded the Nizamshahi dynasty and the town in the 15th century—to be renamed 'Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Nagar' after the 18th century warrior queen Ahilyadevi Holkar. She is venerated by members of the Dhangar (shepherd or pastoral) community, the second-largest caste after the dominant Maratha-Kunbi caste complex.

Meanwhile, the Shinde-led Sena wants Churchgate railway station in south Mumbai to be named after the late RBI governor C.D. Deshmukh,who had resigned as Union finance minister in 1956 to protest the refusal of the Nehru government to accede to the demand of Marathi speakers to form the state of Maharashtra with Mumbai as its capital. Deshmukh is hence a symbol of Marathi pride. "We have demanded that the Churchgate station be renamed after C.D. Deshmukh, who played a major role in the formation of Maharashtra," says Sheetal Mhatre, former Mumbai corporator and spokesperson of the Shinde-led Shiv Sena. However, the demand has been opposed by those who point out that Churchgate station has been an integral part of the city's history and culture for the past 150 years. They have also started an online petition against the move.

A similar demand to rename two more railway stations—Dadar and Mumbai Central—has been made by Dalit groups. "We want Mumbai Cen-

POLITICS OF RENAMING



- In 1994, after a 16-year agitation, Marathwada University in Aurangabad was renamed **DR BABASAHEB AMBEDKAR MARATHWADA UNIVERSITY**. Schisms have still not healed
- The most significant renaming was **BOMBAY TO MUMBAI** (1995) by the then Shiv Sena-BJP government. Later, the iconic Victoria Terminus (VT) station and the airport were named after Chhatrapati Shivaji
- The Elphinstone Road railway station in Mumbai was renamed **PRABHADEVI** (2018) and University of Pune after **SAVITRIBAI PHULE** (2014) for the contributions Mahatma Jyotiba and wife Savitribai Phule made to the cause of educating women and non-Brahmins
- Maharashtra's lone Muslim CM, A.R. Antulay, renamed Kulaba district **RAIGAD** in the early 1980s. Raigad was the fort-capital of Shivaji

...THE NEW DEMANDS

- Pune to Jijaunagar
- Ahmednagar to Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Nagar
- Aurangabad airport after Chhatrapati Sambhaji
- Churchgate railway station after C.D. Deshmukh
- Mumbai Central railway station after Dr Ambedkar or Jagannath 'Nana' Shankarseth
- Dadar railway station as Chaityabhoomi